

The Bibliotheca Alexandrina: History, Mission, and Facilities

The **Bibliotheca Alexandrina (BA)** is a modern commemoration of the ancient Library of Alexandria, intended as a global center of learning and culture. Established by Egyptian law and UNESCO support, it reopened near the historic site in 2002. Under its founding law, BA is a *public juridical entity* attached to the President of Egypt, envisioned as “an Egyptian center of cultural radiance, a beacon for thought, culture and science, encompassing all the products of the human mind in all languages” ¹. Its mission is to collect, preserve and provide access to knowledge (print, manuscripts, audio-visual and electronic) in all fields, with special emphasis on the heritage of Alexandria, Egypt, the Arab world, the Mediterranean and Africa ² ³. In practice, BA serves national and international scholars, general readers and youth alike, and “provides a link to the world’s major research libraries utilizing modern technology” ². According to Egyptian law, BA includes a library, a planetarium, a conference center, and a network of research centers (e.g. for information science, manuscripts, science history, etc.) ⁴. The institution’s broad vision is to revive the spirit of learning and openness that characterized ancient Alexandria, while fostering **peace, dialogue and innovation** through its programs ⁵ ³.

Historical Background

The new Bibliotheca Alexandrina traces its inspiration to the **ancient Library of Alexandria** (3rd century BCE), once the ancient world’s greatest repository of knowledge. Founded under the Ptolemies, the original library gathered up to hundreds of thousands of papyrus scrolls and attracted scholars from across civilizations ⁶. Over centuries it was damaged and eventually lost. In the 20th century the idea of reviving it gained momentum. In the 1970s, scholars like Mostafa El-Abbadi proposed building a new library on or near the original site, and UNESCO endorsed the concept. By 1988 an international design competition was held (won by Norway’s Snøhetta firm) ⁷. Egypt’s President Mubarak laid the cornerstone on 26 June 1988 ⁷. Funding was pledged at an international conference (Aswan, 1990). Construction began in 1994 and the complex (cost ~\$220 million) was completed by 2001 ⁷. The Bibliotheca Alexandrina was officially inaugurated on 16 October 2002 ⁸. (Its opening ceremonies were delayed for regional events but the library had already opened sections for digital collections in 2002 ⁹.)

Since 2002, BA has quickly grown in stature. In 2002 Alexandria was named UNESCO’s World Book Capital (in part due to BA’s revival) ¹⁰. In 2009 France’s national library (BnF) donated 500,000 books, founding a *Francophone Library* and making BA one of the world’s largest French-language collections ¹¹ ¹². Today BA houses **shelf space for eight million volumes**, with its main reading room spanning 20,000 m² over 11 terraces ¹³ ¹⁴. Its facilities include international-standard laboratories for manuscript conservation and digitization, and it has become “an academic powerhouse” hosting ~1,500 programs and over one million visitors per year ⁵.

Architecture and Facilities

The BA building is a striking, modern architectural symbol. Designed by Snøhetta, it is a vast **tilted circular “disk”** 160 m in diameter (32 m high, 12 m sunk) ¹⁵. Its gently sloping roof (often compared to a rising sun or floating disk) is clad in polished granite inscribed with characters from thousands of

world writing systems ¹⁶ ¹⁷ . This 6,000 m² carved stone façade (above and below ground) is one of the world's largest contemporary art projects, celebrating “the smallest written element” – the letter – in all languages ¹⁶ ¹⁷ . Surrounding the tower is an open plaza with a large reflecting pool. The design emphasizes natural light: the library's central reading hall is lit by north-facing skylights, keeping books safe from direct sun ¹⁴ . The structure used 80% locally sourced materials and incorporates passive cooling (water pools, thermal mass) for energy efficiency ¹⁸ .

Inside, the main facility is an **11-story library** with reading halls stepped in terraces. The **central reading room** alone is 20,000 m² (for ~2,000 readers) – formerly the world's largest open reading room ¹⁴ . The terraced design places stacks adjacent to reading desks, greatly reducing book retrieval time ¹⁹ . The BA also contains extensive closed-stack storage (for a total of 8 million volumes) ²⁰ . Beyond books, the building complex integrates many other functions. According to BA descriptions, it “is much more than a library,” comprising:

- **Main Library (General Collection):** holds books, periodicals, and reference works in all fields and languages (especially Arabic, English and French ²¹).
- **Specialized Libraries (6+):** see table below.
- **Planetarium Science Center (PSC):** includes a high-tech **planetarium dome** (reopened 2009) for astronomy shows ²² , a *History of Science Museum* (exhibits on ancient Egyptian, Hellenistic and Arab science ²³), and the *ALEXploratorium*, an interactive hands-on science center for children and youth ²⁴ .
- **Museums (4):** the Sadat Museum (modern Egyptian history), Antiquities Museum (archaeology finds from the site), Manuscripts Museum (rare Arabic manuscripts), and History of Science Museum ²⁵ .
- **Art Galleries:** Several galleries for temporary and permanent art exhibitions (celebrating literature, history, and art – e.g. exhibitions on artists, calligraphy, local heritage).
- **Conference Center (BACC):** connected underground to the library, with large halls and meeting rooms; hosts international conferences, lectures and performances (capacity for thousands) ²⁶ .
- **Cultural Exhibitions:** Multiple permanent exhibitions (Heritage Collections, Awad lithographs, etc.) and an “Our Digital World” exhibition on BA's tech projects ²⁷ .
- **Research Institutes:** The Bibliotheca includes or hosts several research centers (see below) and a manuscript conservation/restoration laboratory.
- **Outdoor Spaces:** A pedestrian footbridge links BA to Alexandria University, and the grounds include promenades and venue spaces.

The following table summarizes BA's specialized library sections:

Specialized Library	Focus / Collections
Main Library	General collection (books, journals, maps, etc.); Dewey arrangement for all subjects ²⁰ .
Arts & Multimedia Library	Fine arts, performing arts, music, photography and all audiovisual materials ²⁸ .
Taha Hussein Library	Library for the blind and visually impaired: Braille books, large-print and audiotape materials ²⁹ .
Children's Library	Books and media for young children (ages 6–11) ³⁰ .
Young People's Library	Books and media for adolescents (ages 12–16) ³¹ .

Specialized Library	Focus / Collections
Exchange & Depository Collections	Official publications and exchange materials (e.g. UN/EU documents) ³² .
Rare Books Section	Rare and historic printed books (pre-1920) and donated special collections ³³ .
Francophone Library	French-language books (established after a 2009 donation of 500,000 books by France's BnF) ¹¹ .

Other key facilities include the Internet Archive mirror and digital collections (see below), and the BA's own **information science lab and conservation labs**. The design has won multiple awards (Aga Khan Award 2004, etc.) and is internationally praised as a modern monument to scholarship ³⁴ ¹⁸ .

Collections and Resources

The Bibliotheca's collections are vast and multi-lingual. The library was **built to hold 8 million volumes** (500,000 on open shelves) ²⁰ . Its general collections use standard Dewey Decimal organization and span *every major field of knowledge* (arts, history, science, technology, literature, etc.) ²⁰ ² . BA contains books in **classical Arabic, English and French** ²¹ and acquisitions cover modern and historical works. In particular, BA emphasizes materials on Egyptian and regional heritage (cultural, historical and scientific) to serve scholars of the Mediterranean and Arab world ² .

Special collections enrich the holdings. These include:

- **Manuscripts and Rare Books:** The Manuscripts Center and Rare Books Section house rare manuscripts, early prints and papyri. BA actively acquires Islamic and Arab manuscripts and has a Manuscripts Museum for public display. (For example, BA mounted a major exhibition of papyrus in 2024.) The Manuscripts Center "indexes, verifies and studies" Arab-Islamic manuscript heritage ³⁵ .
- **Multimedia:** The Arts & Multimedia Library holds music CDs, films, and multimedia art. The PSC has 12D and 4D theaters. BA's audio-visual archives include local TV and a film archive.
- **Electronic Resources and Digital Collections:** BA subscribes to hundreds of electronic databases (science, social sciences, humanities) and e-journals. It also publishes many titles digitally.
- **Internet Archive Partnership:** A hallmark is BA's mirror of the Internet Archive. In 2002–2003, Internet Archive founder Brewster Kahle donated *10 billion archived web pages (1996–2001)* plus 2,000 hours of TV and 1,000 archival films (about 100 TB of data on 200 servers) ³⁶ ⁹ . BA thus hosts the world's second IA center, intended as part of a global digital preservation network ³⁶ ³⁷ . Special "Web Harvesting" projects target Arabic web content for scholars.
- **Digital Heritage Projects:** BA runs numerous digital heritage portals (e.g. *Eternal Egypt, Global Egyptian Museum, Memory of Modern Egypt, Description de l'Égypte*), bringing images and information on Egyptian history and culture to a worldwide audience ³⁸ . These projects illustrate BA's mission to disseminate knowledge via the Internet.
- **Special Collections:** BA's depository holds UN, EU and other government documents ³² . Personal libraries and donations (e.g. the Awad collection of Alexandrian art images, Shadi Abdel Salam archive) form part of Heritage Collections exhibitions ³⁹ ⁴⁰ .

Overall, BA's holdings are exceptionally broad. It calls itself a *research library open to the public*, with "large collections of audiovisual and electronic materials" as well as books and manuscripts ² . The

collection development policy explicitly prioritizes building strength in core fields (science and technology, humanities, etc.) while also preserving cultural heritage materials ⁴¹ ⁴² .

Academic and Cultural Programs

Since its 2002 opening, BA has been an **active cultural and academic hub**. It hosts around **1,500 events per year** – lectures, classes, concerts, workshops, and conferences ⁵ . Many events have international participation. Its “overarching themes” are *peace, democracy, citizenship*, and issues of scientific and cultural innovation ⁵ .

Major recurring events include:

- **Annual International Book Fair:** Starting in 2002, BA organizes a *summer International Book Fair* (in July) showcasing Arab and foreign publishers. The 2025 fair (20th edition) runs 7–21 July 2025, drawing hundreds of publishers (78 regional ones in 2025) and launching new titles ⁴³ ⁴⁴ . The fair includes a rare-books wing and a children’s literature section, and coincides with ~200+ cultural programs (talks, readings, panels) with hundreds of speakers ⁴³ .
- **International Summer Festival:** Every August–September, BA’s Arts Center stages an *Alexandria Summer Festival* of music, theater, comedy and art. For example, the 2023 festival (3 Aug–1 Sept) featured Egyptian and international bands, classical music, stand-up comedy, theater and workshops ⁴⁵ ⁴⁶ . The festival aims at youth engagement and intercultural exchange.
- **Science Fairs and Education:** BA’s Planetarium Science Center launched Egypt’s FIRST LEGO League (2006) and Intel-BA Science & Engineering Fair (BASEF, since 2010) ⁴⁷ . It holds astronomy outreach (planetarium shows like *Sky of Alexandria*), robotics competitions, and public science days ²² . The ALEXploratorium runs year-round science education for children ²⁴ .
- **Conferences and Symposia:** BA’s conference center has hosted major academic conferences in digital libraries (e.g. ICUDL 2006), history, philosophy, science and technology. Notable examples include international meetings on manuscript studies, archaeological heritage, information science, water policy, etc. (specific names not cited here).
- **Exhibitions and Cultural Programs:** BA mounts a continual series of exhibitions on art, history, archaeology and heritage (ancient manuscripts, Islamic calligraphy, modern Egyptian history, etc.). Its Museums put on both permanent displays (e.g. on pharaonic antiquities found onsite, president Sadat’s legacy) and temporary exhibits. Additionally, BA hosts concerts, cinema screenings, poetry readings and educational festivals, often in partnership with other institutions.
- **Educational Workshops and Outreach:** Through its many centers (language, calligraphy, computers, astronomy), BA offers courses for school groups, teacher training, librarian training (notably the **International Librarianship Training Program** for Arab and non-Arab librarians ⁴⁸), and public lectures. It also provides tours and resources for school curricula.

These programs engage the wider community. For instance, the summer Book Fair is described as “*the biggest book fair in the city*” which local intellectuals eagerly anticipate ⁴³ . In 2025 the book fair alone is expected to draw 800+ speakers across 215 parallel events ⁴³ . Over its first two decades, BA estimates over 40 million people have visited its complex.

Research, Education and Outreach

Beyond library services, BA functions as a major research and learning campus. It **houses or supports numerous institutes and centers**:

- **International School of Information Science (ISIS)**: A graduate research institute affiliated with BA, focusing on digital libraries, information technology, and preservation. ISIS develops digital heritage projects (e.g. 'Memory of Modern Egypt') and won awards for engineering achievements ⁴⁹.
- **Manuscripts Center**: Catalogs and studies Arab-Islamic manuscripts, working to index and preserve them ³⁵.
- **Alexandria & Mediterranean Research Center (AlexMed)**: Studies the history and heritage of Alexandria and the Mediterranean, and fosters regional dialogue ⁵⁰.
- **Center for Documentation of Cultural and Natural Heritage (CULTNAT)**: Documents Egypt's tangible and intangible heritage (e.g. digital mapping, GIS, heritage recording) ⁵¹.
- **Serageldin Institute for Multidisciplinary Advanced Research (SIMAR)**: Named after the founding director, an institute for interdisciplinary scholarship (futures studies, social policy, etc.).
- **Centers for Special Studies and Programs, Islamic Civilization, Coptic Studies, Hellenistic Studies, Strategic Studies, Women's Studies, etc.**: These address specialized humanities and social science fields relevant to the region.
- **Zahi Hawass Center of Egyptology**: Focused on Egyptian archaeology and heritage.
- **Media Center**: BA operates a publishing wing and media department producing academic journals, books, and educational programming. (E.g. *SCIplanet* science magazine for youth).
- **Sennari House and Princess Khadija Palace**: Offsite BA centers that host workshops, exhibitions and community events (BA runs cultural outreach programs in these historic houses).

BA also engages internationally. It maintains partnerships with UNESCO (which co-founded the project), library associations (IFLA/UNESCO cultural heritage programs), foreign libraries and universities. The Internet Archive and BnF were noted partners. More recently, BA has led network initiatives like the African Digital Libraries and e-heritage collaborations with other Mediterranean cities.

On the cultural front, BA's outreach includes "*Embassies of Knowledge*" (branch centers abroad) and **BA Information for Africa (BAIFA)** – an e-network providing library resources across Africa (one of BA's ongoing initiatives).

Governance and Administration

Under Egyptian law, BA has a unique governance structure. Presidential Decree No.76 (2001) established three authorities: a **Council of Patrons**, a **Board of Trustees**, and a **Director** ⁵². The Council of Patrons (8–24 global luminaries, including the UNESCO Director-General ex officio, chaired by the Egyptian President) "supports the Library and expresses views on its direction" ⁵³. The Board of Trustees (15–30 eminent figures, Egyptians and foreigners, including the Ministers of Culture, Education, Foreign Affairs, and the Alexandria Governor) is the main policymaking body, defining BA's general policies, budget and regulations ⁵⁴ ⁵⁵. The Board meets at least annually.

The **Director** (Chief Executive) is appointed by the Board for a renewable five-year term from qualified candidates of international stature ⁵⁶. The Director manages day-to-day operations, heads the professional staff, and ensures the board's policies are implemented. BA has its own independent budget (funded by the Egyptian state plus donations, service fees and projects) ⁵⁷ ⁵⁸, and is exempt

from many taxes and customs duties for scientific materials. This governance model is intended to give BA operational flexibility and international oversight befitting a global cultural institution.

Summary: The Bibliotheca Alexandrina is a landmark modern library built to revive the legacy of the ancient Library of Alexandria. Inaugurated in 2002, it combines an iconic circular building (by Snøhetta) with a comprehensive collection and diverse cultural facilities. BA's mission is to be a *bridge between past and future*, serving scholars, readers and the public through its library stacks, museums, planetarium and science center, exhibitions, events and digital outreach. It stands as Egypt's premier knowledge hub for information, science and culture in the 21st century ² ⁵ .

Sources: Information is drawn from the official Bibliotheca Alexandrina website (library and history pages) ⁵⁹ ²⁰ , the Snøhetta architecture profile ⁶⁰ ¹⁴ , Britannica and UNESCO summaries ⁸ ¹⁰ , and news coverage (Library Journal, Ahram Weekly) ⁹ ⁶¹ . These sources provide details on the BA's founding, architecture, collections and activities.

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